A DATA STUDY OF 1,000 BOOTSTRAPPED STARTUPS

The Truth About Building an Online Business

What 1,000 real, revenue-tracked startups tell us about what actually works.

1,000

companies tracked

$100 – $1M+

monthly revenue range

Public

revenue-tracking data

Source: TrustMRR public revenue-tracking data

1

THE LONG TAIL REALITY

Most businesses earn almost nothing.
A handful earn almost everything.

~40%

of the 1,000 companies make under $100/month in revenue

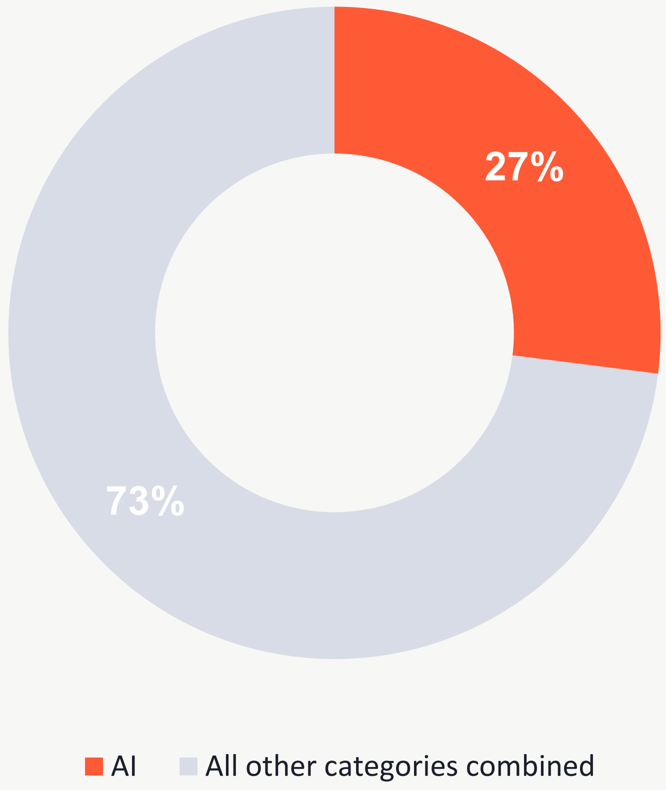
61%

of ALL revenue across the dataset is earned by just the top 10 companies

Starting an online business is a long-tail game — most participants stay small, and a small number of outliers capture the bulk of the reward. This isn't failure, it's the shape of the game.

Source: TrustMRR public revenue-tracking data

1 in 4 startups today is an “AI” company.



27%

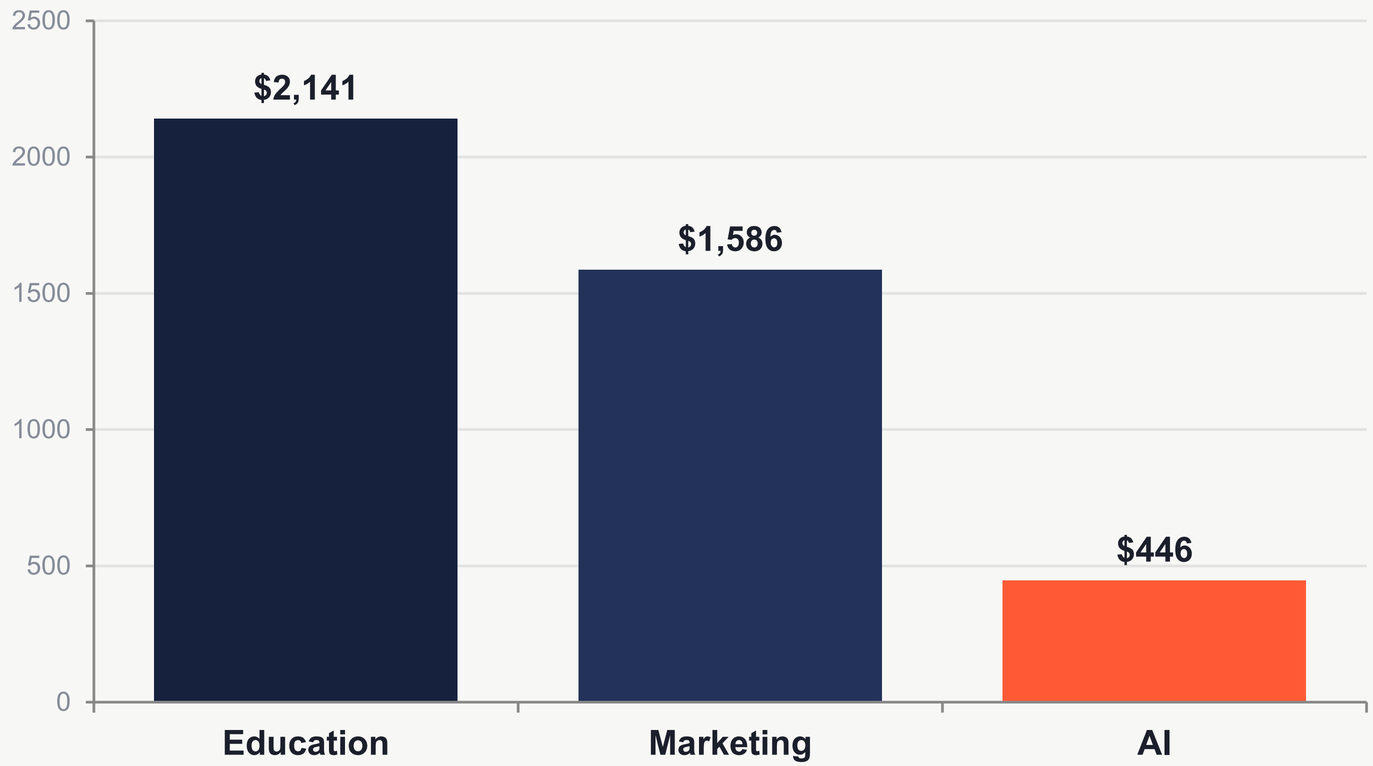
of all categorized businesses describe themselves as “AI” — by far the most crowded category, ahead of SaaS, Productivity, and Marketing combined.

Everyone is racing into the same space at once, betting that “AI” is where the opportunity is.

Source: TrustMRR public revenue-tracking data

CROWDED DOESN'T MEAN PROFITABLE

AI companies aren't the top earners — Education and Marketing are.



Median Monthly Revenue

Education
$2,141

Marketing
$1,586

AI
$446

Chasing the hype category means fighting the most competitors for a below-average slice. Less crowded doesn't mean less lucrative — often the opposite.

Source: TrustMRR public revenue-tracking data

4

WHO YOU SELL TO MATTERS

B2B businesses earn nearly 6x more than B2C — on the same platform, same tools, same playbook.

B2C

$181

median monthly revenue

401 companies — the more common choice

B2B

$1,036

median monthly revenue

255 companies — the less common choice

Founders gravitate toward consumer ideas — they're more fun, more visible — but businesses are more often willing to pay, and pay more.

Source: TrustMRR public revenue-tracking data

5

VANITY vs. REVENUE

Social media following has almost no relationship with revenue.

0.02

correlation between X/Twitter followers and monthly revenue

effectively zero

A big audience feels like traction, but it isn't the same as a business. Some of the highest earners in the dataset have small or no social following at all.

Source: TrustMRR public revenue-tracking data

THE TAKEAWAY

What actually works: build for businesses, avoid the crowd, and measure revenue — not attention.

1

The long tail is real

Most stay small; a few outliers take most of the reward. That's the shape of the game, not a personal failure.

2

Don't chase the hype category

AI draws the most founders but pays a below-median outcome. Less crowded corners often pay more.

3

Sell to businesses if you can

B2B pays nearly 6x what B2C pays for the same effort — even though B2C is the more popular choice.

4

Ignore vanity metrics

Social following barely correlates with revenue. Track revenue, not reach.

The data doesn't say “don't build AI” or “don't build for consumers” — it says be deliberate. The crowd and the followers won't save you; revenue will.